

Transforming Certification for Better Care

ABMS CONFERENCE 2026

ACGME Milestones and ABPN Board Certification

Focused study: Psychiatry and Child & Adolescent
Psychiatry

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Disclosure

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Conflicts of Interest

None to disclose.

Acknowledgment

This project is part of the project supported by the American Board of Medical Specialties Research and Education Foundation. This project is a collaboration among the American Board of Psychiatry and Neurology (ABPN), Accreditation Council for Graduate Medical Education (ACGME), and University of Illinois College of Medicine (UIC).

1. ACGME Milestones: developmental assessment across GME

Formative, longitudinal judgments intended to describe progression toward unsupervised practice.

6 CORE COMPETENCIES

FORMATIVE

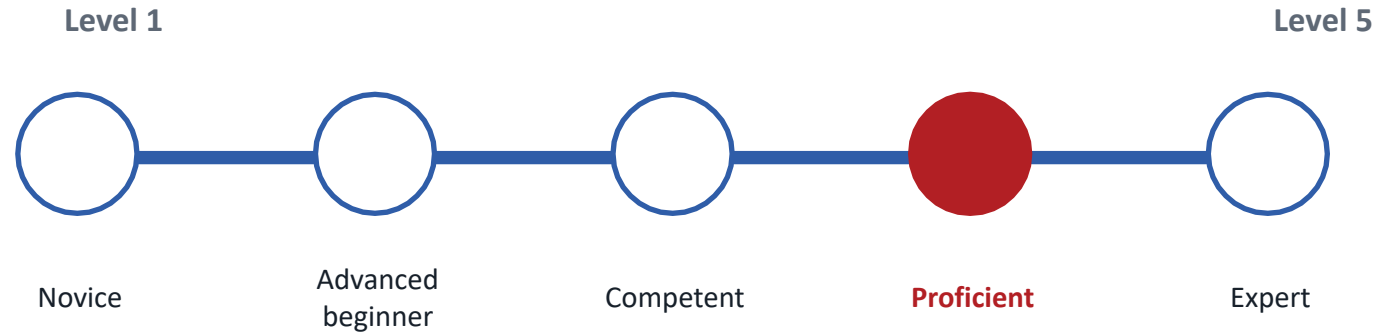
LONGITUDINAL

CCC CONSENSUS

2× / YEAR

What the Milestones do

1. Describe specialty-specific developmental progression
2. Support feedback and identification of strengths / gaps
3. Provide repeated ratings across residency and fellowship
4. Create learning trajectories rather than a single point-in-time score



Graduation target: Level 4 “proficient”

Key consideration for interpretation: Milestone ratings may vary across programs and institutions, and this variation should be considered when analyzing observed associations.

2. ABPN certification: a complementary summative signal

Certification provides an external assessment after accredited training and aligns with ABPN's public-service mission.

ABPN mission

"To serve the public and the profession by promoting lifelong learning and certifying psychiatrists and neurologists to high standards of expertise."

How the signals differ

Milestones

- Locally implemented; not normed or standardized
- Influenced by local assessment strategies
- Synthesized by the Clinical Competency Committee

Certification examinations

- Standardized external assessment
- Based on individual examination performance

Training Assessment → ABPN Certification

ACGME-accredited training

Repeated Milestones ratings



ABPN initial certification

Eligibility + rigorous board examination



Certification outcome

Evidence of readiness

Study question: Are higher graduating Milestones ratings associated with better corresponding ABPN certification outcomes?

3. Literature: Milestones and certification show related but non-equivalent signals

Specialty	Study (Year)	Key Findings	Takeaway
Internal Medicine	Hauer et al. (2016)	• Medical Knowledge (MK) Milestones correlated with ABIM certification scores. • Residents who failed had lower MK ratings.	Supports convergent validity
Vascular Surgery	Weaver et al. (2024)	• Final-year Milestones predicted first-attempt qualifying and certifying exam pass. • Several odds ratios (ORs) were >2, with the highest at 4.73 for PGY-5 Medical Knowledge predicting the Vascular Qualifying Examination .	Strong predictive signal
PM&R	Francisco et al. (2021 / 2024)	• Medical Knowledge predicted Part I. • Milestones did not predict Part II oral/domain scores.	Construct alignment matters
Anesthesiology	Sun et al. (2026)	• Average Milestones correlations with written/oral/OSCE scores were weak. • MK-to-written correlation was modest (r = .289).	Weak overall convergence
Ob/Gyn	Bienstock et al. (2021)	• Milestone ratings were associated with ABOG Qualifying Examination scores, with the strongest associations for Medical Knowledge.	Additional supportive evidence

Synthesis

Milestones and board examinations should not be assumed to measure the same construct. Their relationship appears domain- and assessment-specific, making psychiatry/neurology evidence especially important.

4. Broad project: connect assessment across the training continuum

Aim 1 Align residency and fellowship Milestones

Aim 2 Explore relationships between Milestones and board certification

Aim 3 Study residency → fellowship transitions

Aim 4 Use patterns to inform feedback / coaching

This presentation focuses only on Aim 2: Milestones → corresponding ABPN certification.

5. Focus of this study: two field-specific associations

Competency-level Milestone means from the penultimate year of training were linked to first-attempt ABPN certification.



Primary outcome

First-attempt certification
pass/fail

Milestone predictor

Mean rating aggregated at the six
ACGME competency levels

Model

Random-effects logistic
regression with program
clustering

Six competencies

- Patient Care (PC)
- Medical Knowledge (MK)
- Practice Based Learning and Improvement (PBLI)
- Professionalism (PROF)
- Interpersonal Communication Skills (ICS)
- System Based Practice (SBP)

Psychiatry: 2020–2023 | CAP: 2022–2025

Hypothesis: Higher Milestone ratings are associated with greater odds of passing the corresponding ABPN certification examination on the first attempt.

6. Results: Psychiatry

PGY-3 competency-level Milestones → first-attempt certification pass | n = 4,002

ACGME Competency	OR	(SE)	P-value	95% CI
ICS	2.05	(.25)	< .001	1.61–2.60
MK	3.68	(.52)	< .001	2.79–4.86
PC	3.26	(.49)	< .001	2.43–4.38
PBLI	2.37	(.31)	< .001	1.83–3.07
PROF	2.15	(.25)	< .001	1.71–2.71
SBP	2.73	(.42)	< .001	2.02–3.69

What stands out

MK shows the largest association (OR 3.68).

All six competency domains show statistically significant positive associations with first-attempt certification.

Notably, ICS, PBLI, Professionalism, and SBP also show positive associations—not only MK and PC.

Notes: random-effects regression with clustering by program; Milestones aggregated as competency-level means; PGY-3 year-end Milestones from the penultimate year used. Milestones 1.0 (2020–2023).

7. Results: Child & Adolescent Psychiatry (CAP)

FY-1 competency-level Milestones → first-attempt certification pass | n = 863

ACGME Competency	OR	(SE)	P-value	95% CI
ICS	1.69	(.35)	.012	1.12–2.53
MK	2.18	(.50)	.001	1.38–3.42
PC	2.46	(.59)	< .001	1.54–3.93
PBLI	1.64	(.30)	.007	1.14–2.35
PROF	1.71	(.34)	.007	1.16–2.51
SBP	1.75	(.36)	.007	1.17–2.63

What stands out

PC shows the largest association (OR 2.46).

All six competency domains show statistically significant positive associations with first-attempt certification.

The same broad pattern appears in CAP, although the ORs are generally smaller than in Psychiatry.

Notes: random-effects regression with clustering by program; Milestones aggregated as competency-level means; FY-1 year-end Milestones from the penultimate year used. Milestones 2.0 (2022–2025).

8. Interpretation: a broader competency signal than expected

Medical Knowledge and Patient Care are strongest, but the pattern extends across all six competencies.

Psychiatry

Largest ORs:

MK 3.68 • PC 3.26 • SBP 2.73

All six competencies: $P < .001$

CAP

Largest ORs:

PC 2.46 • MK 2.18 • SBP 1.75

All six competencies: $P \leq .012$

Why this is interesting

The positive associations for ICS, PBLI, Professionalism, and SBP suggest that certification pass outcomes are associated with a broader pattern of trainee performance than knowledge and patient care alone.

Context from Weaver et al. (2024): all core competency ratings predicted first-attempt VQE pass, and all competency ratings also predicted first-attempt VCE pass.

Interpret cautiously: association does not establish that the certification examination directly measures each competency.

9. Conclusions and next steps

The findings support complementary evidence across training and certification, while preserving the distinct purposes of each assessment.

1

Consistent positive association

Higher penultimate-year Milestone ratings were associated with greater odds of first-attempt certification pass in both Psychiatry and CAP.

2

MK and PC are strongest—but not alone

All six competency domains were significant. The positive findings for the harmonized competencies are especially noteworthy.

3

Complementary, not equivalent

Milestones are formative, longitudinal judgments; certification is a standardized summative outcome. Associations should not be interpreted as construct equivalence.

Next analyses

Examine competency-specific patterns, assess robustness to model choices and program effects, and explore whether similar broad competency associations are observed in other specialties/subspecialties.